

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 5

Chapter 7: The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	7 — The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct.

Apex traps: fusing Chandragupta II (Gupta) with Chandragupta Maurya across a centuries-wide gap; reading the Iron Pillar as proof iron 'cannot rust' rather than as a phosphorus-rich passive-layer marvel; mis-crediting the Prayaga Prashasti or treating its court authorship as either flawless proof or worthless flattery instead of partial evidence to cross-check; collapsing the Gupta directly-ruled north-centre into a Mauryan whole-subcontinent model; mistaking 'Golden Age' for social equality when the chandalas were excluded; assuming contemporaries like the Pallavas, Kamarupa or Vakatakas were Gupta subordinates; and confusing which scholar or work belongs to which strand (math/astronomy vs poetry vs medicine vs metallurgy). Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A student reasons: 'Because the Guptas ruled from Pataliputra, the very city the Mauryas had ruled from, and used the title Chandragupta, the Guptas must simply be the Mauryan dynasty restored after a pause.' Identify the single best refutation that uses BOTH the chronology and the political map.

(A) The Mauryas never actually used Pataliputra as a capital, so the entire premise about the shared city is false.

(B) The two dynasties are separated by roughly six centuries with the Kushanas between them, and the Guptas governed the north and centre while the south and northeast had their own kings, so a shared capital and a shared name element cannot make them one continuous dynasty.

(C) The Guptas did in fact descend directly from the Mauryas, so the only error is the word 'restored', which should read 'inherited'.

(D) Because both dynasties ruled the whole subcontinent in exactly the same way, the only difference worth noting is the spelling of the rulers' names.

2. Three claims are made about a single inscription: (i) it praises Samudragupta's conquests; (ii) it was composed by his court poet; (iii) therefore every conquest it lists is certainly true. A careful historian accepts (i) and (ii) but rejects the leap to (iii) because:

(A) court poetry can never be used as evidence at all, so even (i) and (ii) should really be discarded along with (iii).

(B) the author served and depended on the king, so his praise is partial and the listed conquests should be cross-checked against coins, other inscriptions and accounts before being taken as established fact.

(C) the inscription was actually composed by a rival king, which is why its claims cannot be trusted.

(D) the conquests are false only because Samudragupta never fought any wars, being remembered as a man of peace.

3. A museum label reads: 'This 4th-century-CE pillar proves that the iron of ancient India never corroded.' A Class 7 student should object that the label overgeneralises because the correct lesson is:

(A) this particular pillar resists rust because its iron is unusually rich in phosphorus, forming a thin protective film, which shows skilled metallurgy in one object rather than a blanket property of all ancient Indian iron.

(B) the pillar is in fact made of bronze, so it is no evidence about iron of any period at all.

(C) iron really does never corrode, so the label is correct and there is nothing to object to.

(D) the pillar survives only because a fresh rust-proof coating is painted onto it every single year.

4. Suppose only three pieces of evidence survived from the Gupta age: a gold coin showing a king as an archer, a copper-plate grant of a tax-free village, and merchants' graffiti in a Socotra cave. A historian using all three together could most reliably conclude that the Guptas:

(A) ruled the island of Socotra directly and stationed an army there to protect the merchants.

(B) presented their rulers as powerful, recorded land rights in durable writing, and presided over an economy whose merchants traded far across the Indian Ocean.

(C) had abandoned coinage and trade entirely in favour of granting land to brahmins.

(D) kept no written records of any kind and governed purely by spoken command.

5. Chandragupta I married a Licchavi princess; later Prabhavati Gupta, daughter of Chandragupta II, married into the Vakataka house. Taken together, these two marriages best illustrate that the Guptas treated matrimonial alliances as:

- (A) purely private religious ceremonies that had no effect on the dynasty's standing or reach.
- (B) a means of collecting yearly land taxes from the families the Guptas married into.
- (C) a recurring instrument of statecraft, used both to gain prestige from an established line and to extend Gupta influence into an allied kingdom.
- (D) treaties by which the Guptas surrendered their own throne to the Licchavis and then the Vakatakas.

6. A timeline lists, with approximate centuries, the founders and famous rulers of three dynasties: the Mauryas (4th century BCE), the Kushanas (around the 1st-2nd centuries CE), and the Guptas (4th-6th centuries CE). A student who places Samudragupta's conquests in the 2nd century BCE has made an error best described as:

- (A) a minor slip of only a few decades that does not affect the dynasty he belongs to.
- (B) correct as stated, because the Guptas immediately followed the Mauryas with no gap.
- (C) an anachronism of about six hundred years, since Samudragupta was a Gupta of the 4th century CE, not a figure of the Mauryan period.
- (D) an error in dynasty only, since the date itself rightly belongs to a Gupta ruler.

7. Faxian praised Gupta cities for charitable rest-houses and hospitals yet also recorded that the chandalas had to live apart and announce their approach. A student who cites only the first half to argue 'Gupta society was fair to everyone' commits which reasoning error?

- (A) cherry-picking the favourable detail while ignoring the same author's evidence of harsh exclusion, so the conclusion does not follow from the full source.
- (B) trusting a forged document, since the contradiction proves Faxian never visited India.
- (C) rejecting a source for containing one dark detail, which is the opposite of what the student did.
- (D) using a king's praise-inscription rather than an outsider's account, mistaking the type of source.

8. The empire granted many tax-free agrahara villages over several generations. Which chain of consequences best explains why such a generous religious policy could quietly weaken a king's later power?

- (A) Each grant doubled the taxes paid from that land, so the treasury swelled until the king grew too rich to govern.
- (B) Each grant forced the king to disband his army, since grant-holders became the only source of soldiers in the realm.

(C) Each grant ended overseas trade, because merchants could now legally operate only on temple-owned land.

(D) Each grant removed land from the taxed pool and handed local authority to the grant-holder, so over time royal revenue shrank and direct control loosened, leaving the treasury thinner when threats arose.

9. A coin depicts a Gupta king playing the vina (lyre); another shows him as an archer; an inscription on a third names him 'Maharajadhiraja'. Read together as a deliberate programme, this variety most strongly suggests the king wished to be seen as:

(A) a humble servant of villagers who made no claim to authority over anyone.

(B) a wandering pilgrim who had renounced the throne to travel to holy places.

(C) a foreign merchant who had come to India only to purchase gold for export.

(D) a many-sided sovereign, at once a cultured patron and a mighty warrior who stood above other kings.

10. Why is it more accurate to say the Aryabhatiya 'gathered and advanced' results in mathematics and astronomy than to say Aryabhata 'single-handedly invented mathematics'?

(A) Aryabhata wrote only about poetry and love, so the work has nothing to do with mathematics at all.

(B) The text is a concise treatise that organised and pushed forward existing knowledge, such as the place-value system and the idea of Earth's rotation, rather than creating an entire subject from nothing.

(C) The Aryabhatiya is a praise-inscription of a king, so it advanced administration rather than science.

(D) Mathematics had no earlier history anywhere, so 'invented' is exactly the right word for the work.

11. Aryabhata proposed that the daily wheeling of the night sky is caused by the Earth's own spin. Which statement best captures why this was an intellectually bold move rather than a mere description of what anyone could see?

(A) Everyone could plainly see the Earth spinning, so Aryabhata only wrote down the obvious.

(B) What people actually see is the sky turning overhead, so explaining it by an unseen motion of the Earth required arguing against the obvious appearance.

(C) It proved the Earth was flat and rested on a fixed pillar, overturning a round-Earth belief.

(D) It showed the Sun physically races around the Earth once every single night.

12. A student writes: 'Samudragupta wrote the Aryabhatiya and Aryabhata composed the Prayaga Prashasti.' How many distinct mix-ups does this sentence contain, and what are they?

- (A) One mix-up only: just the author of the Aryabhatiya is wrong, while the prashasti credit is correct.
- (B) No mix-up at all: rulers wrote scientific works and scientists wrote royal inscriptions in this era.
- (C) Two mix-ups, but the real ones are that Kalidasa wrote both works and neither name given is genuine.
- (D) Two mix-ups: the Aryabhatiya was written by Aryabhata (not Samudragupta), and the Prayaga Prashasti was composed by Harisena for Samudragupta (not by Aryabhata).

13. Why does the wide global spread of the Indian zero-and-place-value system count as stronger evidence for the Gupta age's lasting importance than, say, the survival of one beautiful Ajanta painting?

- (A) The painting never survived, so there is nothing it could prove in the first place.
- (B) A mathematical system adopted across many later civilisations reshaped how the whole world calculates, a far broader and more enduring influence than a single admired artwork in one place.
- (C) The place-value system was used once and then forgotten, so it is actually the weaker evidence.
- (D) Paintings cannot be evidence of anything, because only numbers can be studied by historians.

14. Prabhavati Gupta governed the Vakataka realm as regent after her husband's death. To call her a 'regent' rather than a 'queen who inherited the throne in her own right' is precise because a regent:

- (A) is a person who travels to holy places and therefore holds no governing role.
- (B) is the court poet who composes verses praising whoever sits on the throne.
- (C) is a foreign ambassador sent to arrange marriages between two royal houses.
- (D) rules temporarily on behalf of a monarch who cannot yet rule, typically a young heir, rather than holding the throne as the sovereign herself.

15. Chandragupta II's defeat of the Shakas (Western Kshatrapas) is often singled out as strategically important. Linking the conquest to trade, the best explanation is that it:

- (A) delivered control of China and an overland road all the way to the Pacific Ocean.
- (B) ended the Mauryan dynasty, which the Shakas had been protecting for centuries.
- (C) yielded the secret of zero, which the defeated Shakas had been keeping hidden.
- (D) brought the western regions and their seaports under Gupta control, opening or securing access to Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean trade routes.

16. A debate runs: 'Was the Gupta state more like the Mauryan model or more like a network of allied kings?' The most accurate single answer, given the chapter, is that it was:

(A) exactly like the Mauryan model, directly ruling every village across the entire subcontinent.

(B) a blend, directly governing the north and centre in a strong central way while relying on land grants and allied or subordinate kings toward the edges.

(C) a pure alliance of equals with no central ruler exercising any direct authority anywhere.

(D) neither, since the Guptas in fact controlled only the single city of Pataliputra and nothing beyond it.

17. Two sources describe Gupta wealth: the Prayaga Prashasti (a court inscription) and Faxian's travel account (an outsider's record). Which statement best explains why combining them gives a sounder picture than either alone?

(A) Both were written by the same court poet for the same king, so combining them simply repeats one voice.

(B) One is partial in the king's favour and the other is an outsider's observation, so where they agree the conclusion is more trustworthy and where they differ a historian knows to dig deeper.

(C) The prashasti is wholly unbiased while Faxian's account is pure invention, so only the prashasti matters.

(D) Neither can be used because both happen to be written documents rather than physical objects.

18. The title 'Maharajadhiraja' ('great king of kings') and the title 'Chakravartin' ('universal sovereign') both appear in the period. Why do such layered titles tell us something about the political structure, not just royal vanity?

(A) They prove the ruler had no kingdom and was merely a village headman with grand words.

(B) They show the ruler had handed all real power to an elected council and kept only the names.

(C) They claim authority over OTHER kings, which only makes sense in a world of many lesser rulers acknowledging a paramount overlord, exactly the layered structure of the Gupta realm.

(D) They indicate the ruler had become a temple priest rather than a political leader.

19. A copper-plate grant is durable; a palm-leaf note is not. Beyond mere survival, what does the deliberate CHOICE of copper for land grants reveal about how the Gupta state and grant-holders thought about land rights?

(A) They wanted a surface light enough to carry on long sea voyages to Rome and back.

(B) They wanted a record the king could easily wipe clean and re-use whenever he wished.

(C) They wanted the rights fixed in a lasting, hard-to-alter form that could be produced as proof across generations, showing land rights were treated as serious, enduring legal claims.

(D) They wanted to melt the plates into coins later, so the writing was never meant to last.

20. If a newly found inscription names a king as 'Vikramaditya' and lists patronage of poets and scientists, but says nothing of conquests, which earlier-discussed Gupta ruler does it most plausibly fit, and why?

(A) Samudragupta, because he alone is celebrated for conquests, which this inscription clearly emphasises.

(B) Chandragupta I, because he founded the empire and so must be the one called 'Vikramaditya'.

(C) Chandragupta Maurya, because the title 'Vikramaditya' was first used in the Mauryan period.

(D) Chandragupta II, because 'Vikramaditya' and a court rich in poets and scientists match the ruler remembered for cultural splendour rather than for the great conquests credited to Samudragupta.

21. A student claims Faxian's account and a Gupta gold coin are 'equally biased toward making the empire look good.' Why is this a misreading of the difference between the two sources?

(A) The coin was issued by the rulers to project their own power, while Faxian was an outside visitor with no stake in flattering the dynasty, so they are biased in different ways and degrees, not equally.

(B) Both were minted by the Gupta treasury, so they really are equally official royal propaganda.

(C) Faxian was a paid Gupta court official, so his account is even more flattering than the coin.

(D) Neither has any bias whatsoever, so calling them 'equally biased' is the only correct view.

22. Why is it misleading to say 'the Guptas conquered Socotra because Indian merchants left graffiti there'?

(A) Because the graffiti was actually left by Socotrans who had invaded northern India, reversing the direction of travel.

(B) Because Socotra was in fact the Gupta capital, so no conquest was needed to explain Indian presence there.

(C) Because Indian merchants never reached Socotra, so the graffiti must be a modern forgery.

(D) Graffiti by visiting traders shows that merchants travelled and traded there, which is evidence of commercial reach, not of military conquest or political rule over the island.

23. Consider the claim: 'The Gupta age was a Golden Age, so it must have been a fair and equal society.' Which part of this is sound and which is the flaw?

(A) Both parts are sound, because cultural brilliance in this era did go hand in hand with full social equality.

(B) The 'Golden Age' label is sound for cultural and scientific brilliance, but the leap to 'fair and equal' is the flaw, since groups such as the chandalas were excluded and treated harshly.

(C) Both parts are flawed, because the era produced no notable culture and so was not golden in any sense.

(D) The 'fair and equal' part is sound, but calling it a Golden Age is the flaw, since its art and science were ordinary.

24. Which single conclusion is BEST supported by the fact that the Pallavas (Kanchipuram), Kamarupa (Brahmaputra valley) and the Vakatakas all flourished during the Gupta period?

(A) The Gupta empire was a north-centred power that shared the subcontinent with several independent or allied regional kingdoms rather than ruling it all.

(B) The Guptas were the only kingdom anywhere in India, and these names were merely their provinces.

(C) India was at the time governed as a single province of China through these three houses.

(D) These kingdoms were tiny Gupta villages with headmen rather than rulers of their own.

25. A textbook dates the Guptas to roughly the 4th-6th centuries CE. A student adds four facts. Which one, if asserted as true, would force the student to REJECT the textbook's dating as inconsistent?

(A) 'Chandragupta I strengthened the dynasty in the early 4th century CE.'

(B) 'The Hunas pressed hard on the empire during the 6th century CE.'

(C) 'Samudragupta led his great conquests in the 2nd century BCE.'

(D) 'Aryabhata wrote his treatise around 500 CE, at the cultural peak.'

26. Why does the survival of the rust-resistant Iron Pillar tell historians something different about the Gupta age than the survival of a Gupta gold coin does?

- (A) Both objects tell us only the weight of the metal used and nothing else about the period.
- (B) The pillar shows the Guptas imported all metal from Rome, while the coin shows they made none.
- (C) The pillar testifies to advanced iron-working and metallurgical skill, whereas the coin testifies more to the economy, royal imagery and the rulers' self-projection.
- (D) Both objects prove the Guptas could work only gold and no other metal at all.

27. A scholar writes that 'the same king could be a fearsome conqueror, a generous patron, and a claimant to universal sovereignty.' Which combination of evidence from the chapter best fits a single Gupta ruler answering this description across two generations of the dynasty's image?

- (A) Faxian's pilgrimage, the Socotra graffiti and the Ajanta paintings, which all describe foreign visitors to India.
- (B) The Hunas' invasions, the decline of revenue and the rise of the Pallavas, which all describe the empire's fall.
- (C) Samudragupta's conquests recorded in the Prayaga Prashasti, Chandragupta II's patronage of Kalidasa and the sciences, and the dynasty's titles such as Chakravartin together show conqueror, patron and universal-sovereign claims.
- (D) The agrahara grants, the codifying of Ayurveda and the founding by Chandragupta I, which all describe administration alone.

28. The chapter calls the Gupta era an 'Age of Tireless Creativity.' Which set of examples would a careful student offer as the **STRONGEST** justification of that exact phrase?

- (A) A single famous coin minted in one year, which alone captures the whole creative spirit of the age.
- (B) The repeated Huna invasions, which kept the empire endlessly busy defending its frontiers.
- (C) The collection of yearly land taxes, which required tireless effort from the king's officials.
- (D) Sustained output across many fields at once: Aryabhata in mathematics and astronomy, Kalidasa in literature, Varahamihira's encyclopedic work, the codifying of Ayurveda, and the art of Ajanta and Sarnath.

29. Suppose two coins survive: one of Samudragupta and one of Chandragupta II. A student insists 'the older coin must be Chandragupta II's, since II comes after I.' Untangle the confusion.

- (A) The numeral 'II' distinguishes two kings both named Chandragupta and does not rank them against Samudragupta; in dynasty order Chandragupta I came first, then his son Samudragupta, then Chandragupta II, so Samudragupta's coin is the older of the two.
- (B) The student is right: 'II' always means a ruler is later than every other king in the dynasty.
- (C) Both coins are equally old, because all Gupta rulers reigned at exactly the same time.
- (D) Chandragupta II actually ruled before Samudragupta, so his coin is indeed the older one.

30. An assertion-reason pair: **ASSERTION:** A historian should not take the Prayaga Prashasti as the final word on Samudragupta's empire. **REASON:** It was carved on stone, and stone records are always false. Choose the best judgement.

- (A) Both the assertion and the reason are true, and the reason correctly explains the assertion.
- (B) The assertion is false, because a court inscription should be accepted as completely neutral fact.
- (C) Both are false, because the prashasti is reliable in every detail and stone records are always true.
- (D) The assertion is true but the reason is false: the caution comes from its partial, praise-driven authorship by a court poet, not from being carved on stone, which actually helps it survive.

31. Why is it more historically careful to say 'Gupta gold coins broadcast royal claims that must be read critically' than to say either 'they are neutral facts' or 'they are worthless lies'?

- (A) Because the coins were never actually used, so they tell us nothing and the question is moot.
- (B) Because the coins carry no images or titles at all, so there is nothing to read critically.
- (C) Because only written inscriptions count as evidence, so coins should be set aside entirely.
- (D) The coins are genuine dateable objects revealing rulers, wealth and imagery, yet their pictures and titles were chosen to flatter, so they are real evidence that still needs critical reading rather than blind trust or blanket rejection.

32. A student groups four names as 'Gupta-court scientists': Aryabhata, Varahamihira, Kalidasa, and Harisena. Which name is misplaced, and why?

- (A) Only Kalidasa is misplaced; Harisena was indeed a noted Gupta-age scientist.
- (B) Only Aryabhata is misplaced, since he was actually a poet rather than a scientist.

(C) None is misplaced, because in the Gupta court every scholar worked equally as a scientist.

(D) Both Kalidasa and Harisena are misplaced as scientists: Kalidasa was a poet-playwright and Harisena was a court poet who composed the Prayaga Prashasti, so neither belongs with the mathematician-astronomers.

33. The chapter notes that scholars came from distant lands to study at Nalanda. Used carefully, what is the SOUNDEST inference this fact supports about Gupta-age India?

(A) Indians themselves were forbidden to study at Nalanda, which was reserved for foreigners only.

(B) Its centres of learning had a reputation strong enough to attract students internationally, marking India as a hub of advanced study in the period.

(C) Nalanda was really a military fortress, and the 'scholars' were soldiers in disguise.

(D) The Guptas had banned all study inside their own borders, forcing learning to happen elsewhere.

34. Two travellers' or observers' reports could in principle disagree. If Faxian praised Gupta charity but a hypothetical second visitor stressed the suffering of the chandalas, the correct historian's response would be to:

(A) treat both as partial windows on the same society and conclude that prosperity and charity coexisted with harsh exclusion, rather than choosing one report and discarding the other.

(B) accept only the cheerful report and reject the one mentioning suffering, since the age was golden.

(C) reject both reports outright, because two accounts that differ must both be forgeries.

(D) assume the second visitor never came to India, since Faxian's praise already settles the matter.

35. Which statement best explains why mounting Huna invasions and decades of tax-free land grants are treated as RELATED causes of Gupta decline rather than two unconnected events?

(A) They are unrelated: the grants strengthened the treasury, so only the Hunas mattered to the decline.

(B) The Hunas were themselves grant-holders, so the two causes are literally the same single event.

(C) The grants had thinned the treasury and loosened central control over time, so when the Hunas pressed in, the weakened state had fewer resources to resist, linking a slow internal drain to a sharp external shock.

(D) The grants caused the Hunas to migrate, because tax-free land attracted them from Central Asia.

36. Why does the recurring entry of groups like the Hunas 'through the northwest' over many centuries support a geographical, not merely a Gupta-specific, lesson?

(A) Because many different peoples entered by the same route across different eras, the northwest is best seen as a long-standing gateway into the subcontinent, a pattern larger than any one dynasty's fortunes.

(B) Because only the Hunas ever used that route, the lesson is specific to the Gupta decline alone.

(C) Because the northwest was sealed by impassable mountains, no group could ever enter that way.

(D) Because the northwest was India's main seaport, the invaders must have arrived there by ship.

37. A student equates 'agrahara' with 'prashasti.' Correct the error by stating what each actually is.

(A) Both are the same thing: a tax-free village whose deed doubles as a king's praise-poem.

(B) An agrahara is a praise-inscription and a prashasti is a tax-free village, so the student merely swapped the labels correctly.

(C) An agrahara is a (usually tax-free) grant of land or a village to brahmins or temples, while a prashasti is a praise-inscription recording a king's achievements; one is a land grant, the other a text.

(D) Both are gold coins, one issued to brahmins and the other to court poets.

38. Why is it more accurate to credit the Gupta-age 'codifying' of Ayurveda to systematic organisation rather than to first invention of medicine?

(A) Codifying means destroying the old medical texts, so the Guptas in fact ended medical knowledge.

(B) Codifying means arranging and writing down existing healing knowledge in an organised, systematic form, building on earlier practice rather than inventing medicine from scratch.

(C) Codifying means keeping the knowledge a permanent secret, so it was never written down at all.

(D) Codifying means translating the texts into Greek, so Ayurveda was created abroad.

39. Garuda, the vahana of Vishnu, appears as a royal emblem on Gupta symbols. Read together with the patronage of Buddhist Ajanta paintings, what is the best conclusion about Gupta-age religion?

(A) The Guptas worshipped only foreign Greek gods and rejected all Indian religious imagery.

(B) The Guptas ruled as a strictly Buddhist-only dynasty and banned Hindu symbols like Garuda.

(C) The Guptas drew on Hindu imagery to sanctify their rule yet also patronised Buddhist art, so the period supported more than one religious tradition rather than a single exclusive faith.

(D) The Guptas had no interest in religion and used Garuda merely as a random decorative bird.

40. A claim runs: 'Since Chandragupta II was titled Vikramaditya (the 'Sun of Valour') and led the empire's cultural peak, valour and the arts must be the same thing.' What is the precise logical flaw?

(A) It treats a poetic royal title as a literal equation; the title praises the king's bravery while his reign's fame for the arts comes from his patronage, so two distinct things are wrongly fused by a name.

(B) There is no flaw, because in this period military valour and artistic skill were literally identical.

(C) The flaw is that 'Vikramaditya' actually means 'King of Kings', so the title is about rank, not valour.

(D) The flaw is that Chandragupta II had no cultural achievements, so the premise about the arts is false.

41. Which single piece of reasoning most strongly supports the judgement that royal women could wield real political power in the Gupta period, while avoiding overstatement?

(A) Prabhavati Gupta governed the Vakataka realm as regent after her husband's death, an actual exercise of political authority, even though most rule still lay with kings.

(B) Royal women personally commanded the empire's armies in every major battle of the age.

(C) Only foreign-born queens were ever allowed to govern, and Prabhavati was foreign-born.

(D) Women held no role whatsoever in governance, which is why Prabhavati's case is never mentioned.

42. A student says the Aryabhatiya, the Brihat Samhita and the Meghadutam are 'three Gupta-age science treatises.' Identify the misclassification.

(A) The Meghadutam is misclassified: it is a poem by Kalidasa, whereas the Aryabhatiya (Aryabhata) and the Brihat Samhita (Varahamihira) deal with mathematics and astronomy/encyclopedic knowledge.

(B) The Aryabhatiya is misclassified, since it is actually a love poem and not a science work.

(C) The Brihat Samhita is misclassified, since it is actually a praise-inscription of Samudragupta.

(D) None is misclassified, because all three were written as treatises on astronomy.

43. Why is the agreement between three independent kinds of evidence — a royal inscription, dateable coins, and overseas merchant graffiti — considered especially persuasive about Gupta prosperity and reach?

- (A) Because a single one of them would already have proved everything, so the other two add nothing.
- (B) Because the three are of different types and origins, their convergence on the same picture is much harder to explain by chance or by one source's bias than a single source would be.
- (C) Because all three were produced by the same court poet, making their agreement automatic.
- (D) Because agreement among sources shows that physical objects can now be ignored in favour of texts.

44. Place these in correct order of how a historian SHOULD reason about a praise-inscription, from first step to conclusion.

- (A) Accept every claim as fact first, then look for who wrote it only if challenged later.
- (B) Reject the whole inscription immediately, then ignore any other evidence entirely.
- (C) Note who wrote it and for whom, recognise the likely bias, cross-check its claims against other evidence, then accept the parts that are corroborated.
- (D) Assume the inscription was secretly written by an enemy, then treat its praise as hidden mockery.

45. Compared with a Mauryan-style empire trying to tax and administer every region directly, the Gupta reliance on land grants and allied kings would tend to make the empire:

- (A) permanently stronger, because each grant and ally added guaranteed soldiers and taxes to the centre.
- (B) completely unchanged, since land grants and direct taxation have identical effects on a treasury.
- (C) richer over time, because tax-free grants returned more revenue than taxed land ever could.
- (D) easier to hold together in good times but more fragile under sustained pressure, because central revenue and direct control gradually leaked away to grant-holders and allies.

46. A student argues: 'The Iron Pillar and the discovery of zero both show the same thing — that Gupta India led the world in every field.' What is the most precise correction?

- (A) They show nothing, because neither the pillar's metal nor zero was actually an Indian achievement.
- (B) The correction is that both are really achievements of the Mauryan, not the Gupta, period.

(C) They show real excellence in two specific fields, metallurgy and mathematics, which supports 'outstanding achievement in several areas', not the sweeping claim of leading the world 'in every field'.

(D) There is no need to correct anything, since two examples are enough to prove world leadership in every field.

47. Why would mis-dating the Aryabhatiya to the Mauryan period be a more serious error than mis-spelling 'Aryabhata'?

(A) It is not more serious, because the date of a scientific work never matters to historians.

(B) A wrong date severs the work from its true historical context and the Gupta intellectual flowering around 500 CE, distorting cause and setting, whereas a spelling slip leaves the historical placement intact.

(C) It is less serious, because the Mauryan period is when the Aryabhatiya was actually written.

(D) Both errors are identical, since a name and a date carry exactly the same historical weight.

48. If a historian found a copper plate granting a tax-free village 'by order of Maharajadhiraja', which TWO chapter themes would the single document simultaneously illustrate?

(A) Both the Indian Ocean trade with Socotra and the rust-resistance of the Iron Pillar.

(B) Both Aryabhata's astronomy and Kalidasa's poetry at the royal court.

(C) Both the Huna invasions from the northwest and the codifying of Ayurveda.

(D) Both the land-grant administration recorded in durable writing and the king's claim to paramount authority signalled by the grand title.

49. A student claims, 'The Pallavas must have been Gupta subordinates, since the Guptas were the greatest power of the age.' Why does 'greatest power' NOT license that conclusion?

(A) Because the Pallavas were in fact more powerful than the Guptas and ruled the north too.

(B) Because the Pallavas and the Guptas were the same dynasty under two different names.

(C) Being the strongest power does not mean ruling every region; the Pallavas had their own capital at Kanchipuram and ruled the south independently, so Gupta prominence does not make them subordinates.

(D) Because the Guptas had no power at all, so no one could have been their subordinate.

50. Why is it sounder to call the Gupta age India's 'Classical Age' on cultural grounds than to call it so on grounds of political unity?

- (A) Because the Guptas politically unified the whole subcontinent, which is the only basis for the label.
- (B) Because the period produced no notable culture, the label can only rest on its politics.
- (C) Because political unity and cultural achievement mean exactly the same thing for this era.
- (D) Its lasting models in art, science and literature give the period a 'classical' standard later ages looked back to, whereas politically India was divided among the Guptas, Pallavas, Kamarupa and others rather than unified.

51. A coin inscription survives reading only '...gupta, Chakravartin, victorious in many lands.' On internal evidence alone, why can a historian NOT immediately decide whether it names Samudragupta or Chandragupta II?

- (A) Both rulers used grand sovereign titles and both are linked to military success, so a fragment praising conquest and universal sovereignty fits more than one Gupta king and must be dated and cross-checked before attribution.
- (B) Because only Samudragupta ever fought wars, the fragment can be assigned to him with certainty at once.
- (C) Because the title 'Chakravartin' was used only by Chandragupta II, the attribution is immediate and sure.
- (D) Because the suffix '-gupta' proves it must be Chandragupta Maurya of the Mauryan dynasty.

52. Which statement most precisely distinguishes Samudragupta's and Chandragupta II's contributions, avoiding the common conflation?

- (A) Samudragupta is remembered chiefly for wide military conquest recorded in the Prayaga Prashasti, while Chandragupta II is remembered chiefly for cultural patronage and the linkage of the 'Chandra' Iron Pillar to his reign.
- (B) Both are remembered only as patrons of poets, with neither associated with any military activity.
- (C) Samudragupta is remembered for the Iron Pillar and Chandragupta II for the Prayaga Prashasti.
- (D) Both are simply other names for Chandragupta Maurya at different stages of his life.

53. A study group ranks four reasons the Gupta era is celebrated. Which reason is HISTORICALLY UNSOUND and should be struck from the list?

- (A) 'It produced enduring science such as the work of Aryabhata and the place-value system.'
- (B) 'It produced lasting literature such as the works of Kalidasa, still performed today.'

(C) 'It achieved complete social equality, with no group excluded or treated harshly.'

(D) 'It supported skilled art and metallurgy, from Ajanta paintings to the rust-resistant Iron Pillar.'

54. Why does pairing 'Kumaragupta' with 'the Chinese pilgrim who toured India' reveal a category error, not just a wrong name?

(A) There is no error, since Kumaragupta did travel from China to tour India as a pilgrim.

(B) The only error is the spelling of 'Kumaragupta', who was indeed the touring pilgrim.

(C) It places a Gupta ruler in the slot of a foreign visitor; Kumaragupta was a king of the dynasty while the pilgrim who toured India was Faxian, so the two belong to entirely different categories of person.

(D) The error is that the pilgrim was actually Samudragupta, another Gupta ruler.

55. Why is the spread of the place-value system across other civilisations evidence of INFLUENCE rather than of CONQUEST?

(A) Ideas can travel through trade, scholarship and copying without armies, so the adoption of a useful calculating system abroad shows intellectual influence, not that India ruled those lands.

(B) Because the lands that adopted it must have been conquered by the Guptas to learn it.

(C) Because the system never actually left India, so neither influence nor conquest is involved.

(D) Because only a conquering army can ever transmit a mathematical idea from one land to another.

56. A student claims the Gupta period was 'purely peaceful, which is why it produced so much culture.' Which evidence most directly refutes the 'purely peaceful' part while leaving the cultural achievement intact?

(A) The codifying of Ayurveda, which proves the era saw no fighting of any kind.

(B) Samudragupta's many recorded conquests and the later Huna invasions show the era included significant warfare, even though it also produced great culture.

(C) The minting of gold coins, which shows the empire never needed an army.

(D) Kalidasa's plays, which demonstrate that no war occurred during the whole period.

57. Which comparison best captures how a prashasti and a copper-plate grant differ in PURPOSE, even though both are official inscriptions?

(A) Both exist only to praise the king, so their purposes are effectively identical.

(B) A prashasti exists to glorify a ruler's deeds, while a copper-plate grant exists to record a specific transfer of land rights, so one is praise and the other is a legal-administrative record.

(C) A prashasti records land transfers while a copper-plate grant praises the king's conquests.

(D) Neither has any purpose beyond decoration, since inscriptions were never meant to be read.

58. An examiner's summary reads: 'The Gupta legacy is best stated as lasting contributions in math, science, literature and art that influenced India and the world, alongside a society that remained unequal.' Why is this judged the most accurate one-line legacy?

(A) It holds together both halves of the evidence — the genuine, far-reaching cultural and scientific achievements and the persistence of social inequality such as the exclusion of the chandalas — without exaggerating either.

(B) Because it claims the era left nothing of value and is remembered only for its decline.

(C) Because it claims the era achieved perfect equality while producing no notable culture.

(D) Because it credits the whole legacy to Chandragupta Maurya and the Mauryan state.

59. A historian remarks that 'the Guptas held their empire together less by an army on every street than by a web of relationships.' Which combination of chapter evidence best supports this characterisation?

(A) Matrimonial alliances such as the Licchavi and Vakataka marriages, land grants creating ties of obligation, and reliance on allied and subordinate kings at the empire's edges.

(B) The discovery of zero, the rust-resistant Iron Pillar and the Ajanta paintings, which were achievements in science and art.

(C) Faxian's pilgrimage, the Socotra graffiti and the Nalanda scholars, which describe travel and learning.

(D) The Huna invasions, the Pallava capital and the Brahmaputra valley, which describe rivals and the fall.

60. A student concludes, 'Because Aryabhata gave an accurate value for pi and explained the sky's turning by the Earth's spin, Gupta science had already discovered everything modern science knows.' What is the most precise correction?

(A) Aryabhata's results were in fact wrong, so Gupta science discovered nothing worth crediting.

(B) Modern science is identical to Gupta science, so the conclusion is exactly right with no correction needed.

(C) These results belong to the Mauryan, not the Gupta, period, so they say nothing about Gupta science.

(D) These were genuine, advanced results for their time and deserve real credit, but a few brilliant findings are not the whole of modern science, so the conclusion overstates what the evidence shows.

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 7: The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity — Paper 5

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, -1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	B	11	B	21	A	31	D	41	A	51	A
2	B	12	D	22	D	32	D	42	A	52	A
3	A	13	B	23	B	33	B	43	B	53	C
4	B	14	D	24	A	34	A	44	C	54	C
5	C	15	D	25	C	35	C	45	D	55	A
6	C	16	B	26	C	36	A	46	C	56	B
7	A	17	B	27	C	37	C	47	B	57	B
8	D	18	C	28	D	38	B	48	D	58	A
9	D	19	C	29	A	39	C	49	C	59	A
10	B	20	D	30	D	40	A	50	D	60	D

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

- (B)** Correct: Pataliputra served both dynasties but they are separated by centuries with the Kushanas in between, and unlike the Maurya ideal the Guptas only directly held the north and centre, so neither the shared city nor the shared name proves continuity. The claim that the Mauryas never used Pataliputra is false and contradicts the textbook. The claim of direct descent is invented; the Guptas were a distinct later dynasty. The claim that both ruled the whole subcontinent identically is wrong because the Gupta polity left the south and northeast to their own rulers, which is precisely part of the refutation.
- (B)** Correct: a court poet writing in praise of his patron produces a partial source, so the conquests are plausible but must be triangulated with coins and other evidence rather than swallowed whole. Saying court poetry is worthless overcorrects and would wrongly discard the true premises (i) and (ii). The 'rival king' idea contradicts the fact that Harisena was

Samudragupta's own court poet. Saying Samudragupta never fought wars is flatly wrong: he is remembered above all as an expansionist warrior king.

3. (A) Correct: the marvel is specific to this pillar's phosphorus-rich iron and its passive layer, demonstrating advanced skill on one object, not that all ancient iron is rust-proof. The bronze claim is false; it is an iron pillar. Saying iron never corrodes repeats the very error being criticised. The annual-repainting claim is invented; the resistance is inherent to the metal, not a coating.

4. (B) Correct: each source supports one inference, and together they show royal self-projection (coin), documented administration (copper plate) and long-distance maritime trade (graffiti). Graffiti by visiting merchants shows travel and trade, not Gupta rule over Socotra. The coin and graffiti show coinage and trade continued, so 'abandoned coinage and trade' is contradicted by the very evidence listed. The copper plate is itself a written record, so 'no written records' is self-contradicting.

5. (C) Correct: the Licchavi match lent the young dynasty prestige and the Vakataka match (with Prabhavati later governing as regent) projected Gupta influence outward, showing a consistent political use of marriage. Calling them purely religious ignores their clear political payoff. Marriages were not tax-collection devices. The Guptas did not surrender their throne; they gained allies and influence.

6. (C) Correct: Samudragupta ruled in the 4th century CE, so dating him to the 2nd century BCE misplaces him by roughly six centuries into the Mauryan era. It is not a minor slip of decades but a span-of-dynasties error. The Guptas did not immediately follow the Mauryas; the Kushanas lay between. The date is wrong too, not merely the dynasty, since no Gupta ruled in the 2nd century BCE.

7. (A) Correct: the student selects only the flattering half of Faxian's own report and ignores his note on the chandalas, so the 'fair to everyone' conclusion is unsupported by the complete source. Nothing here shows the document is forged or that Faxian never visited. The student did not reject the source; he over-relied on part of it. The source is Faxian's travel account, not a prashasti, so the 'wrong type of source' label is inaccurate.

8. (D) Correct: tax-free grants subtract from taxable land and transfer local authority, so cumulative grants erode revenue and direct control, a weakness that tells when invasions like the Hunas' arrive. Tax-free land paid no tax, so 'doubled the taxes' is the reverse of the truth. Grants did not abolish armies. Grants did not confine merchants or end trade; that conflates a fiscal policy with maritime commerce.

9. (D) Correct: the lyre projects cultured patronage, the archer projects martial power, and 'great king of kings' projects supremacy, so the combined message is a multi-faceted, paramount ruler. A humble servant making no claim contradicts the supreme title. A

renouncing pilgrim contradicts a king minting royal coins. A foreign merchant contradicts both the kingly imagery and the royal title.

10. (B) Correct: the Aryabhatiya is a compact treatise that systematised and extended known results (place-value, Earth's rotation, an accurate π), so 'gathered and advanced' fits better than 'invented from nothing'. It is not a poetry work; that confuses Aryabhata with Kalidasa. It is not a prashasti; that confuses it with the Prayaga inscription. Mathematics had a long prior history, so 'invented the subject' is false.

11. (B) Correct: the senses suggest a still Earth under a moving sky, so attributing the motion to the Earth contradicts immediate appearance and required real abstraction. No one can see the Earth spin, so it was not 'obvious'. The idea concerns rotation, not a flat Earth on a pillar. It is the Earth's spin, not the Sun racing nightly, that the proposal invokes.

12. (D) Correct: both attributions are swapped wrongly, since Aryabhata wrote the Aryabhatiya and Harisena (not Aryabhata) wrote the Prayaga Prashasti praising Samudragupta. It is not a single error; both halves are wrong. It is false that kings wrote treatises and scientists wrote royal eulogies as a rule. Kalidasa wrote neither of these two works, so the 'Kalidasa wrote both' option introduces a new false claim.

13. (B) Correct: a calculating system taken up worldwide transformed global mathematics, giving it broader and longer reach than a single localised artwork, however fine. Ajanta paintings did survive, so the premise of the first distractor is false. The place-value system was not forgotten; it spread and endured. Paintings are valid historical evidence, so dismissing them entirely is wrong.

14. (D) Correct: a regent governs in place of a monarch unable to rule, usually a child heir, which is exactly Prabhavati's role for her sons rather than reigning as sovereign. A traveller to holy places is a pilgrim. A composer of praise-verse is a court poet. An envoy arranging marriages is an ambassador. Only the regent definition fits.

15. (D) Correct: defeating the Shakas gave the Guptas the western lands and ports, strengthening their reach into Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean trade. The conquest had nothing to do with China or the Pacific. The Mauryan dynasty had ended centuries earlier and was not under Shaka protection. Zero was an Indian mathematical achievement, not a Shaka secret.

16. (B) Correct: the Gupta state mixed direct rule over the north-centre core with looser reliance on grants and allied kings at the margins, so neither pure model fits alone. It was not the whole-subcontinent direct rule of the Maurya ideal. It was not a leaderless alliance; there was a strong emperor. It controlled far more than just Pataliputra. The blend answer captures both halves.

17. (B) Correct: a partisan inscription and an independent traveller's report check each other, so agreement strengthens a claim and disagreement flags it for further study. They were not by the same author for the same king; one is Harisena's eulogy, the other Faxian's travel record. The prashasti is partial, not unbiased, and Faxian is not pure invention. Both being written does not make them unusable; written sources are central evidence.

18. (C) Correct: titles asserting kingship over kings presuppose subordinate rulers beneath a paramount one, mirroring the tiered Gupta political order. A village headman has no kings beneath him, so that reading empties the title of meaning. There was no elected council holding the real power. A temple priest reading ignores that these are sovereign, not priestly, titles.

19. (C) Correct: choosing copper shows an intent to make land rights permanent and provable over generations, evidence of an organised, documented administration. Copper plates were not chosen for sea-voyage portability to Rome. Copper is durable precisely so the grant could NOT be easily erased. Melting them for coins would defeat the purpose of recording a lasting grant.

20. (D) Correct: 'Vikramaditya' and cultural patronage are the hallmarks of Chandragupta II, whose reign is remembered for art and learning rather than for the great conquests. The inscription explicitly omits conquests, so it does not fit conquest-famed Samudragupta. Chandragupta I is the founder of imperial status, not the 'Vikramaditya' patron of culture. Chandragupta Maurya is a different dynasty centuries earlier.

21. (A) Correct: the coin is deliberate royal self-projection, whereas Faxian was an independent foreign pilgrim, so their biases differ in source and strength rather than being equal. Faxian did not mint coins; he wrote travel notes. He was not a paid court official. And neither is entirely bias-free, so 'no bias at all' is also wrong; the point is the kinds of bias differ.

22. (D) Correct: traders' graffiti demonstrates trade and travel, which is a commercial footprint, not proof of conquest or rule. The graffiti was left by Indian merchants, not invading Socotrans. Socotra was a distant island, not the Gupta capital (Pataliputra was). And the graffiti is genuine evidence of Indian merchants reaching the island, not a forgery.

23. (B) Correct: 'Golden Age' rightly praises the period's culture and science, but inferring social equality is the error because the chandalas faced harsh exclusion. It is not true that brilliance went with full equality; that is the misconception itself. The era clearly produced major culture, so 'no notable culture' is false. And its art and science were exceptional, so calling the Golden Age label the flaw is backwards.

24. (A) Correct: contemporary kingdoms in the south, northeast and Deccan show the Guptas held the north-centre while others ruled their regions, so India was not one Gupta realm. These were full kingdoms, not Gupta provinces or villages. India was not a Chinese

province. The conclusion that follows is shared, multi-kingdom subcontinent, not Gupta monopoly.

25. (C) Correct: placing Samudragupta's conquests in the 2nd century BCE puts a Gupta ruler centuries before the empire's own start date, contradicting the 4th-6th century CE frame. The other three (Chandragupta I in the early 4th century, the Hunas in the 6th, Aryabhata around 500) all sit comfortably inside the stated span and so are consistent, not contradictory.

26. (C) Correct: the pillar is evidence of skilled metallurgy (corrosion-resistant iron) while the coin is evidence of economy and royal imagery, so they illuminate different facets. Neither is reducible to bare metal weight. The pillar shows domestic iron skill, not Roman imports. And the iron pillar itself disproves any claim that the Guptas worked only gold.

27. (C) Correct: conquest (Samudragupta/Prayaga Prashasti), patronage (Chandragupta II/Kalidasa) and universal-sovereign titles (Chakravartin) jointly match the conqueror-patron-overlord description. The visitors-and-art set is about outsiders and art, not a king's three-fold image. The Hunas-and-decline set is about the empire's fall. The administration-only set covers governance, not conquest and universal sovereignty together.

28. (D) Correct: 'tireless creativity' is justified by sustained, many-sided creative output in science, literature, scholarship, medicine and art together. A single coin in one year is too thin to support 'tireless' across fields. Huna invasions are destructive pressure, not creativity. Tax collection is administration, not the creative flowering the phrase names.

29. (A) Correct: the 'II' only separates the two Chandraguptas; the succession is Chandragupta I, then Samudragupta, then Chandragupta II, so the Samudragupta coin predates the Chandragupta II coin. 'II' does not mean later than every king. The rulers did not reign simultaneously. Chandragupta II followed, not preceded, Samudragupta, so his coin is the younger.

30. (D) Correct: the assertion stands (treat it critically) but the reason is wrong, since the problem is partisan authorship, not the stone medium, which aids preservation. 'Both true and reason explains' fails because the reason is false. The assertion is not false; court inscriptions are not neutral. And the prashasti is not reliable in every detail, so the all-false option is wrong too.

31. (D) Correct: coins are authentic, dateable sources that also carry deliberate royal messaging, so the balanced stance is 'real evidence, read critically'. The coins were used in a trading economy, not unused. They do carry images and titles, which is exactly what must be read critically. And physical objects like coins are valid evidence alongside inscriptions, not to be set aside.

32. (D) Correct: Aryabhata and Varahamihira were scientists, but Kalidasa (poet-playwright) and Harisena (court poet of the prashasti) were literary figures, so two names are misplaced. Harisena was not a scientist, so 'only Kalidasa' is wrong. Aryabhata was indeed a scientist, so calling him misplaced is false. And the scholars had distinct specialisms, so 'none misplaced' is wrong.

33. (B) Correct: drawing students from afar shows Nalanda's international reputation as a centre of advanced learning. Nothing suggests Indians were barred; that inverts the openness the fact implies. There is no basis for a 'military fort' reading. And the Guptas patronised learning rather than banning study within their borders.

34. (A) Correct: differing reports each capture part of a complex society, so the historian synthesises them into 'brilliance alongside inequality' rather than discarding either. Keeping only the cheerful report repeats the cherry-picking error. Disagreement does not make accounts forgeries. And one favourable report does not settle the matter or disprove another observer.

35. (C) Correct: cumulative grants drained revenue and weakened central control, leaving the state less able to repel the Huna invasions, so an internal weakness and an external shock combine. The grants reduced, not strengthened, the treasury. The Hunas were Central Asian invaders, not grant-holders. And the grants did not lure the Hunas; the Hunas migrated for their own reasons through the northwest.

36. (A) Correct: repeated entries by varied peoples over centuries mark the northwest as a recurring overland gateway, a geographic pattern transcending the Guptas. Many groups, not only the Hunas, used it, so it is not Gupta-specific. The route was passable, not sealed. And it was an overland gateway, not a seaport, so arrival by ship is wrong.

37. (C) Correct: an agrahara is a land/village grant (often tax-free) to brahmins or temples; a prashasti is a eulogistic inscription of a king's deeds; they are different kinds of thing. They are not the same object. The 'swapped correctly' option reverses both definitions, so it is still wrong. And neither is a gold coin.

38. (B) Correct: to codify is to organise and record existing knowledge systematically, so Ayurveda was structured, not invented from nothing. Codifying is the opposite of destroying texts. It means writing knowledge down, not hiding it as a secret. And it does not mean translating into Greek or originating abroad; Ayurveda is the indigenous 'science of life'.

39. (C) Correct: a Hindu royal emblem alongside patronage of Buddhist art shows support for multiple traditions, not one exclusive faith. They did not worship only Greek gods. They were not Buddhist-only banning Hindu symbols; Garuda is a Hindu emblem they used. And Garuda's choice as Vishnu's vahana was religiously meaningful, not random decoration.

40. (A) Correct: the argument over-reads a praise-title; 'Sun of Valour' honours bravery while the artistic flowering reflects patronage, so equating valour with the arts confuses two distinct facts joined only by a name. Valour and art are not literally identical. 'Vikramaditya' means 'Sun of Valour', not 'King of Kings'. And Chandragupta II's reign genuinely was a cultural peak, so the premise about the arts is true, not false.

41. (A) Correct: Prabhavati's documented regency is concrete evidence of real political power without claiming women generally ruled. The 'commanded every army' option overstates well beyond the evidence. The 'only foreign queens' claim is invented and Prabhavati was a Gupta princess. And the 'no role at all' option is contradicted by her case itself.

42. (A) Correct: the Meghadutam is Kalidasa's poem, not a science treatise, while the other two are scientific/encyclopedic works, so it is the misfit. The Aryabhatiya is a mathematics-astronomy treatise, not a love poem. The Brihat Samhita is Varahamihira's encyclopedic work, not a prashasti. And since the Meghadutam is poetry, 'none misclassified' is false.

43. (B) Correct: independent sources of different kinds converging is strong corroboration, since shared bias or coincidence is unlikely across them. A single source would not already prove everything; that is why corroboration matters. The three were not all by one author; they are independent. And convergence does not license ignoring physical objects; coins and graffiti are themselves physical evidence.

44. (C) Correct: sound method is authorship -> bias -> cross-check -> accept corroborated parts, which is exactly the discipline the chapter models with the Prayaga Prashasti. Accepting everything first reverses the method and invites error. Rejecting it whole discards genuine evidence. Assuming secret enemy authorship is an unfounded leap, not careful reasoning.

45. (D) Correct: a grant-and-ally system can run smoothly when unchallenged but loses central revenue and control over time, so it is more brittle under prolonged strain like the Huna invasions. Grants did not guarantee added central taxes; they removed taxable land. The two systems are not identical in effect; that is the whole contrast. And tax-free grants by definition returned less, not more, revenue.

46. (C) Correct: two strong examples justify excellence in those specific fields, not blanket superiority everywhere, so the overreach is 'every field'. Both the pillar and zero were genuine Indian achievements, so 'nothing' is wrong. They belong to the Gupta age, not the Mauryan. And two examples cannot establish leadership in every field, so 'no correction needed' is mistaken.

47. (B) Correct: dating it to the Mauryan era detaches the text from its real Gupta-age context and the flowering around 500 CE, distorting how we understand it, while a

misspelling does not move it in time. Dates do matter for context. The Aryabhatiya was not Mauryan; it is Gupta-age. And a misplaced date and a misspelling are not of equal historical weight.

48. (D) Correct: a titled copper-plate grant shows the documented land-grant system AND the king's supreme-overlord self-presentation in one object. Overseas trade and the Iron Pillar are unrelated to a land grant. Aryabhata and Kalidasa concern science and literature, not a grant deed. The Hunas and Ayurveda are about decline and medicine, not this document's two themes.

49. (C) Correct: even the leading power need not rule everywhere, and the Pallavas governed the south from Kanchipuram on their own, so Gupta prominence does not subordinate them. There is no basis for the Pallavas ruling the north or being mightier. The two were distinct dynasties, not one under two names. And the Guptas clearly were a major power, so 'no power at all' is false.

50. (D) Correct: 'Classical' rests on enduring cultural models, since politically the subcontinent was shared among several kingdoms, not unified. The Guptas did not unify the whole subcontinent, so that basis fails. The period produced rich culture, so 'no notable culture' is false. And cultural achievement and political unity are not the same thing, which is the very distinction at issue.

51. (A) Correct: shared sovereign titles and military fame mean a conquest-praising fragment could fit either king, so dating and corroboration are needed before attribution. Chandragupta II also won wars (the Shakas), so 'only Samudragupta fought' is false. 'Chakravartin' was a general claim of paramount kings, not unique to one. And '-gupta' marks the Gupta, not the Maurya, dynasty, so the Chandragupta Maurya reading is doubly wrong.

52. (A) Correct: conquest and the prashasti belong to Samudragupta; cultural patronage and the 'Chandra' pillar to Chandragupta II, which keeps the two distinct. It is false that neither had military activity, since Samudragupta was a great conqueror. The 'pillar/prashasti' option swaps the correct attributions. And neither is Chandragupta Maurya, a separate Mauryan ruler centuries earlier.

53. (C) Correct: the equality claim is unsound because the chandalas were harshly excluded, so it must be struck. The other three — enduring science, lasting literature, and skilled art and metallurgy — are all well-supported reasons the era is celebrated and rightly stay on the list.

54. (C) Correct: a Gupta king is being slotted into the role of a foreign pilgrim, mixing two categories, when the touring pilgrim was Faxian. Kumaragupta did not travel from China; he was a Gupta ruler. It is not a mere spelling issue. And the pilgrim was Faxian, not Samudragupta, so naming another Gupta king repeats the same category error.

55. (A) Correct: useful ideas spread peacefully via trade and scholarship, so worldwide adoption shows influence, not Gupta rule abroad. Adoption did not require conquest. The system clearly did leave India and spread, so 'never left' is false. And mathematical ideas plainly travel without armies, so the 'only conquest transmits ideas' claim is wrong.

56. (B) Correct: Samudragupta's conquests and the Huna invasions establish real warfare, refuting 'purely peaceful' while the culture still stands. Codifying Ayurveda is a cultural achievement and says nothing about the absence of war. Gold coins do not show the empire lacked an army. And Kalidasa's plays are literature, not evidence that no war occurred.

57. (B) Correct: the prashasti's purpose is eulogy; the copper-plate's purpose is to document a land grant, so they serve praise versus legal-administrative ends. They are not both mere praise. The 'grant praises conquests / prashasti records land' option swaps the two purposes. And inscriptions were certainly meant to be read and to last, not mere decoration.

58. (A) Correct: the best summary keeps both the real, world-influencing achievements and the enduring inequality together, matching the full evidence without overstatement. Saying it left nothing ignores its huge contributions. Saying it had equality but no culture inverts the facts on both counts. And crediting the Mauryan state confuses two dynasties separated by centuries.

59. (A) Correct: marriage alliances, obligation-creating land grants and reliance on allied kings are exactly the 'web of relationships' that bound the realm, contrasting with direct rule everywhere. Zero, the pillar and Ajanta are cultural-scientific achievements, not the bonds of governance. Faxian, Socotra and Nalanda concern travel and learning. The Hunas, the Pallavas and Kamarupa describe rivals and decline, not the Guptas' own binding ties.

60. (D) Correct: an accurate pi and the rotation insight are genuinely impressive for the era, but a handful of results does not equal all of modern science, so the leap is an overstatement. The results were sound, not wrong. Modern science is not identical to Gupta science; centuries of further discovery followed. And these are Gupta-age, not Mauryan, achievements, so dismissing them as Mauryan is mistaken.